

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 1NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♥Q

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: East

Lead: ♠A

Board: 3

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Lead: ♠Q

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: West

Lead: ♠K

Board: 5

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: North

Lead: ♥K

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ J 7 5 4

♥ 9 6

♦ K Q 10 9

♣ Q 8 4

♠ A 2

♥ K 7 4 2

♦ A 8 6 3

♣ A 10 5



♠ K 6 3

♥ Q J 10 8 3

♦ J

♣ K J 6 2

♠ Q 10 9 8

♥ A 5

♦ 7 5 4 2

♣ 9 7 3

West

North

East

South

1NT

All Pass

1NT by North

Lead: ♥Q

Win the first trick with the ♥K. Then play ♠A followed by ♠2. Continue playing ♠s until the ♠K is forced out. Win whatever they play next and play your other winners. You cannot be stopped from taking 7 tricks.

Imagine what would have happened if you had taken the first trick with dummy's ♥A.

What would you try next? A ♠ finesse? Whether East took his ♠K right then or later you would go down. You could never reach dummy again.

You have 7 points so you know your side does not have a game. You also have no reason to think there is any better contract than 1NT. So you pass.

South would play 1NT. To make life more convenient the hands will be rotated so that North becomes declarer.

North plays 1NT. East leads the ♥Q.

North plays 1NT. East leads the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 5

You need two more winners. Even if the ♦s split 3-2 you can get only one more from that suit. So clearly you must use the ♠ suit. Since you have only one entry to dummy you must save it until the right time.

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 10 6 4
♥ K Q 7
♦ 8 6
♣ J 7 5 3 2

♠ 9 8 2

♥ 5

♦ Q 10 7 4 2

♣ A K 9 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ Q J 5

♥ A J 10 9 6 3

♦ A K 5

♣ Q

♠ A K 7 3

♥ 8 4 2

♦ J 9 3

♣ 10 8 4

West

North

East

South

2♥

Pass

4♥

Pass

All Pass

4♥ by East

Lead: ♠ A

is about as bad as it could be.

You have a nice hand, but 20 points is not strong enough to open 2♣.

So you open 1♥. Partner raises to 2♥.

Partner's raise to 2♥ shows 6-10 points. You figure that should be enough for game but even if he has the full 10 you are not in slam range. So you bid the game.

East plays 4♥. South leads ♠ A, then switches to ♥ 2.

East plays 4♥. South leads ♠ A, then switches to ♥ 2.

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

It's a good thing you stopped at game - partner's hand

The PLAN turns out simple. You can't avoid either of the three black losers so you must eliminate the ♦ loser. You can ruff it in dummy. Just to be safe you pull one more round of trumps, then play ♦ A, ♦ K and ♦ 5, ruffing in dummy. You will eventually get to your hand (with a ♠ or a ♣ ruff) and pull the last trump.

This PLAN was not difficult.

Only a real beginner would have pulled all the trumps and not been able to ruff that ♦.

Board 3

East Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 8 2

♥ 10 8 6

♦ 7 5 4

♣ A 5

♠ 7 4

♥ K 5 3

♦ A K 9 6 2

♣ K Q 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 6 5 3

♥ Q 9 7 4

♦ 10 8

♣ 9 7 4

♠ A 9

♥ A J 2

♦ Q J 3

♣ J 10 8 6 2

West

North

East

South

Pass

1♦

Pass

1♣

Pass

3NT

Pass

1NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♠Q
the ♠K.

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 5 : ♣ 0 : Total = 8

Let's say you hold up on the first ♠, hoping they switch suits. HA! They aren't about to switch suits and they drive out your ♠A at trick 2. That actually clears the situation up and makes this plan pretty simple to make.

You have taken 1 ♠, and you will surely make 5 ♦s. Despite the solidity of those ♣s you dare not try to win a ♣ trick, because the defenders will pounce on that first ♣ and then win a bunch of ♠ tricks.

So that makes it clear that you need 3 ♥ tricks, and there's only one way to get them. After taking your five ♦ tricks, play a ♥ to the ♥K, then a ♥ back, finessing the ♥J. Half of the time you will make this contract, the other half of the time they will bury you with ♠s.

You might think if you could just sneak one ♣ through you wouldn't have to depend on the ♥ finesse. But put yourself in West's chair. Do you really think he will let you win a ♣ when he sees he can defeat you by taking his ♣A and leading ♠ winners?

With 16 points as Responder you are not quite strong enough for a jump-shift to 2♦. That requires at least 17 points. A jump to 3NT fits the point range (16-18) but promises a stopper in all unbid suits. So instead you bid 1♦, knowing partner is forced to keep the bidding alive. He now replies 1NT. What is your next bid?

Until now you were thinking the hand might end up in a slam. Now, with partner's minimum rebid, you happily say 3NT which partner passes.

North would play 3NT.

Click

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠Q. East puts on the ♠K.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠Q. East puts on

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ 10 6 3
♥ A 10 7 5 4
♦ A J 2
♣ A K

♠ K Q J 8
♥ -
♦ 9 7 6 4
♣ Q 10 6 5 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 9 5 2
♥ K Q 9 2
♦ K Q 8 3
♣ J 7

♠ A 7 4
♥ J 8 6 3
♦ 10 5
♣ 9 8 4 3

West	North	East	South
1♥	Pass	3♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by West

Lead: ♠K

With no more outside losers your task is very very simple:**DO NOT LOSE A TRUMP TRICK.**

There is no problem if trumps split 2-2 or 3-1, so you can put your mind to 4-0 splits only. If North holds ♥ J 8 6 3 then it won't matter whether your first trump play is ♥A or ♥K, you will still be able to finesse the ♥J. But if South holds ♥ J 8 6 3 it is vital that you first play either the ♥K or ♥Q. If you start with the ♥A you will have lost your finesse position. The general rule is to first play a high trump from the hand that has two. That preserves a finesse through either defender's ♥ J x x x.

Visualize the situation if your first play was the ♥A. North would show out and you would learn that South held ♥ J 8 6 3 but you couldn't do anything about it.

Next visualize the situation if your first play was the ♥K. North would show out and you would play the ♥Q, then a small ♥ finessing your ♥10.

Finally visualize the situation if your first play was the ♥K and it was South who showed out. You would play a small ♥ to your ♥A, then lead a ♥ toward dummy finessing with the ♥9.

Using the correct Plan guarantees the contract however ♥s split.

You have 12 points which isn't quite enough to force to game.

It is just right for a limit raise though, so you bid 3♥.

Partner does bid the game.

East would play 4♥.

Click

West plays 4♥. The defense takes the first three ♠ tricks, then switches to a ♣.

West plays 4♥. The defense takes the first three ♠ tricks, then switches to a ♣.

Losers: ♠ 3 : ♥ ?? : ♦ 0 : ♣ 0 : Total = 3+??

Board 5

South Deals

N-S Vul

♠ -
♥ A 8 7 4
♦ Q J 6 3 2
♣ 10 7 6 4

♠ A 8 7 5 4

♥ 10 6 3

♦ A 8

♣ A J 2



♠ J 10 6 3

♥ K Q J

♦ 10 9 5 4

♣ 9 5

♠ K Q 9 2

♥ 9 5 2

♦ K 7

♣ K Q 8 3

West	North	East	South
			1 ♣
Pass	1 ♠	Pass	2 ♠
Pass	4 ♠		
All Pass			

4 ♠ by North

Lead: ♥K
between J 8 6 3 and J 10 6 3.

Partner has opened and you have 14 points. You know you belong in game but there is no need to jump and use up bidding space. You respond 1 ♠.

Partner now bids 2 ♠.

You know you should be in game and now you know the suit. You bid 4 ♠.

North plays 4 ♠. The defense quickly takes three ♥ tricks, then switches to a ♦.

North plays 4 ♠. The defense quickly takes three ♥ tricks, then switches to a ♦.

Losers: ♠ 0? : ♥ 3 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 0 : Total = 3?

This Deal is **VERY** similar to Deal 9 in that you are only worried about a 4-0 trump split. The reason that it shows up right here is to point out the difference

If West holds ♠ J 10 6 3 then there is nothing you can do about it - you will go down. If you lead a ♠ from dummy he will "split his honors" by playing the ♠10. This will force your ♠A and he can just sit back and wait for his ♠J to make a trick.

But if it is East with ♠ J 10 6 3 you can keep him from winning a ♠ trick, **IF YOUR FIRST ♠ PLAY IS THE ♠A**. West shows out and you play a small ♠ toward dummy's ♠ K Q 9. If East plays low you insert the ♠9, if he plays one of his honors you win it, then return to your hand and finesse him out of the other honor.

When East holds four trumps you can pick them up if your first ♠ play is the ♠A.

If your first ♠ was ♠K or ♠Q then it would be too late.

When West holds four trumps there is no way to avoid a loser. As soon as you lead the first small ♠ from dummy West will play the ♠10. That will force your ♠A and leave him with ♠ J 6 3 behind dummy's ♠ K Q 9.

To summarize: If you are missing **J x x x** your first play should be from the hand with two honors. Then you will be able to finesse in either direction. If you are missing **J 10 x x** your first play should be honor from the hand with only one. This will leave you with a double-finesse position in one direction. If the other defender has the trumps there is nothing you can do.